

Taiichi Ohno

The Toyota Production System & the 5 Whys

1912–1990 · Engineer & executive, Toyota · father of the Toyota Production System



1 WHY THIS THINKER MATTERS

Long before 'lean startup', Ohno built the discipline of learning your way to the root cause. His 5 Whys is the simplest, most durable problem-clarification tool in this course — proof that rigorous thinking needs no technology, only persistence.

2 INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

Japanese industrial engineer and Toyota executive, principal architect of the Toyota Production System (TPS) and lean manufacturing. His shop-floor methods for eliminating waste and finding root causes reshaped global operations.

"Having no problems is the biggest problem of all."

"Ask 'why' five times about every matter."

3 FRAMEWORKS · TOOLS · MODELS

NAME	WHAT IT IS
Toyota Production System	Waste-eliminating, just-in-time production system
The 5 Whys	Iterative questioning to the root cause
Genchi genbutsu	'Go and see' at the actual place
Just-in-time / Kanban	Pull-based flow to reduce inventory waste
Kaizen	Continuous, incremental improvement

4 HOW IT'S OPERATIONALIZED

- Ask 'why?' until a fixable root cause emerges
- Go to the actual place to see the real problem
- Attack process and system causes, not people
- Pursue continuous small improvements (kaizen)
- Base decisions on direct observation, not reports

5 LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUES

- 5 Whys can stop at a convenient, not true, cause
- Single-thread causation may miss multi-causal problems
- Quality depends on the asker's knowledge
- Manufacturing origins need adaptation to services
- Can be applied superficially as a checklist

6 ENDURING IMPACT

- Founded lean manufacturing, now global practice
- 5 Whys embedded in quality and design-thinking toolkits
- Influenced the Lean Startup and agile movements
- Reframed problems as system, not individual, failures
- Direct anchor for BCOBM126 Unit 4 root-cause work

SELECTED WORKS

TOYOTA PRODUCTION SYSTEM <i>Beyond Large-Scale Production</i> OHNO · 1988	WORKPLACE MANAGEMENT <i>Genba Press</i> OHNO · 1982	THE MACHINE THAT CHANGED THE WORLD (contrib.) WOMACK · 1990	JUST-IN-TIME FOR TODAY <i>Productivity Press</i> OHNO · 1988
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REFERENCES (HARVARD · CITE THEM RIGHT)

Ohno, T. (1988) *Toyota Production System: Beyond Large-Scale Production*. Portland, OR: Productivity Press.
 Liker, J.K. (2004) *The Toyota Way*. New York: McGraw-Hill.